

Delete the ordeal of booking train tickets from your memory...

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Finally! A dot-com (www.irctc.co.in—dot-co-dot-in, in this case), that actually helps us commoners, those of us with credit cards, or bank accounts with

Internet banking facilities. The Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC) Web site takes away the drudgery of booking Railway tickets. Enter details, such as your name, date of birth, your home and office addresses, e-mail address, and choose a user-name and password. Log in using your user-name and password and start the process.

Click on the 'Plan my Travel' link under the header Book Ticket on the navigation bar. Now choose the 'From' and 'To' station codes, if you know them. If you don't know the station code, click on the little engine logo on the right of each field to search for stations. Once you find the correct station codes, enter them and choose the date on which you plan to travel, then the Class you want to travel by, and click on Go. Next, you'll see a list of trains to choose from, all spanning the stations you want. Now you can check the radio button next to the train of your choice and click any of the buttons below. The Book Ticket button takes you straight to actu-

IRCTC.co.in

ally booking the ticket; the Get Fare button will show you how much you will be paying for this trip; Show Availability will tell you whether seats are still available; and finally the Show Route button will show you all the stations the train stops at, and at what respective time.

Once you have checked the availability, and the fare, you can click on Book Ticket. Here, you will have to fill in the details of each traveller (up to 6 people), and choose either to deliver the ticket to your home, office, or to another address. After this, you have reach the final step of the booking process. Your booking details are shown, and if everything is fine, click on Make Payment. You will see a popup that will let you choose to pay by credit card, or by the various banks that let you pay via their Net banking services.



Making the payment

If you are paying by credit card, select either of the three options—ICICI Bank's gateway, Citi Bank's gateway, or the American Express gateway. You're taken to a secure site where you enter your card details. Your order will be confirmed and then you're directed back to www.irctc.co.in

If you choose to make the payment through the Internet Banking facility, then simply choose your bank in the window that pops up when you click on Make Payment. You will be taken to the Web site of your bank, where you go through the standard online payment procedure. Once you are done, you can go back to the IRCTC site and click on Booked Tickets to see if the tickets have been booked.

If for some reason you don't see your tickets there, click on the Failed Payments to see whether your transaction failed due to some reason. In that case, you will have to go through the above procedure again. Hey, nothing's perfect!

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